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**HE DECCAN QUEEN**, A crown jewel of the Indian railways, is heritage on rails. India's first electric express train, launched in 1930, runs between Pune and Mumbai. So, when it switched to a diesel locomotive in April this year, it was unsettling for railway enthusiasts. The reason? A shortage of high-power electric locomotives required to pull the train on the steep inclines of the Western Ghats.

In an increasingly climate-conscious

world, where there is a rush for electric mobility, India is witnessing a slowdown in the availability of electric locomotives. Adding to the woes is a scarcity in diesel locomotives, mostly due to stabling since 2022 following the ramp-up of the electrification drive. Stabling is keeping idle or storing of locomotives. The shortage is pinching even freight train operators.

Experts say the production of electric locomotives has not kept pace with track